

Prayer and meditation are very important factors in deepening the spiritual life of the individual, but with them must go also action and example, as these are the tangible results of the former. Both are essential.

*(Shoghi Effendi; from a letter written on his behalf, 15 May 1944)*

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There is nothing sweeter in the world of existence than prayer. Man must live in a state of prayer. The most blessed condition is the condition of prayer and supplication. Prayer is conversation with God. The greatest attainment or the sweetest state is none other than conversation with God. It creates spirituality, creates mindfulness and celestial feelings, begets new attractions of the Kingdom and engenders the susceptibilities of the higher intelligence.

*(‘Abdu’l-Bahá; as quoted in the Diary of Mirza Ahmad Sohrab, 15 March 1914)*

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Prayer need not be in words, but rather in thought and attitude. But if this love and this desire are lacking, it is useless to try to force them. Words without love mean nothing. If a person talks to you as an unpleasant duty, with no love or pleasure in his meeting with you, do you wish to converse with him?

*(‘Abdu’l-Bahá; as quoted by Miss E. S. Stevens in an article published in the Fortnightly Review, 1911)*

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And when you pray, do not be like the hypocrites, for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and on the street corners to be seen by others. Truly I tell you, they have received their reward in full. But when you pray, go into your room, close the door and pray to your Father, who is unseen. Then your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you. And when you pray, do not keep on babbling like pagans, for they think they will be heard because of their many words. Do not be like them, for your Father knows what you need before you ask him.

*(Jesus Christ; from in His Sermon on the Mount, as quoted in The Holy Bible (NIV), Matthew 6:5-8, c. AD 27)*

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It is an axiomatic fact that while you meditate you are speaking with your own spirit. In that state of mind you put certain questions to your spirit and the spirit answers: the light breaks forth and the reality is revealed. [...]

The spirit of man is itself informed and strengthened during meditation; through it affairs of which man knew nothing are unfolded before his view. Through it he receives Divine inspiration, through it he receives heavenly food.

Meditation is the key for opening the doors of mysteries. In that state man abstracts himself: in that state man withdraws himself from all outside objects; in that subjective mood he is immersed in the ocean of spiritual life and can unfold the secrets of things-in-themselves. To illustrate this, think of man as endowed with two kinds of sight; when the power of insight is being used the outward power of vision does not see.

*(‘Abdu’l-Bahá; from a talk given at the Friends’ Meeting House, St. Martin’s Lane, London, UK, 12 January 1913)*

...[I]t is natural that God will give to us when we ask Him. His mercy is all-encircling. But we ask for things which the divine wisdom does not desire for us and there is no answer to our prayer. His wisdom does not sanction what we wish. We pray, "O God! Make me wealthy!" If this prayer were universally answered human affairs would be at a standstill. There would be no one left to work in the streets, no one to till the soil, no one to build, no one to run the trains. Therefore it is evident that it would not be well for us if all prayers were answered. The affairs of the world would be interfered with, energies crippled and progress hindered. But whatever we ask for which is in accord with divine wisdom, God will answer. Assuredly!

*(‘Abdu’l-Bahá; from a talk given in Dublin, New Hampshire, as quoted by Howard MacNutt, 5 August 1912)*

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Prayer is the essential spiritual conversation of the soul with its Maker, direct and without intermediation. It is the spiritual food that sustains the life of the spirit. Like the morning’s dew, it brings freshness to the heart and cleanses it, purifying it from attachments of the insistent self. It is a fire that burns away the veils and a light that leads to the ocean of reunion with the Almighty. On its wings does the soul soar in the heavens of God and draw closer to the divine reality. Upon its quality depends the development of the limitless capacities of the soul and the attraction of the bounties of God, but the prolongation of prayer is not desirable. The powers latent in prayer are manifested when it is motivated by the love of God, beyond any fear or favour, and free from ostentation and superstition. It is to be expressed with a sincere and pure heart conducive to contemplation and meditation so that the rational faculty can be illumined by its effects. Such prayer will transcend the limitation of words and go well beyond mere sounds. The sweetness of its melodies must gladden and uplift the heart and reinforce the penetrating power of the Word, transmuting earthly inclinations into heavenly attributes and inspiring selfless service to humankind.

*(The Universal House of Justice; from a message addressed to the Bahá’ís in Iran, 18 December 2014)*

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Meditation is a way for nourishing and blossoming the divinity within you.

*(Amit Ray; Meditation: Insights and Inspirations, 4 July 2010)*

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In the highest prayer, men pray only for the love of God, not because they fear Him or hell, or hope for bounty or heaven ... When a man falls in love with a human being, it is impossible for him to keep from mentioning the name of his beloved. How much more difficult it is to keep from mentioning the Name of God when one has come to love Him. ... The spiritual man finds no delight in anything save in commemoration of God.

*(‘Abdu’l-Bahá; as quoted by Miss Alma Robertson and other pilgrims, November and December 1900)*

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The inspiration received through meditation is of a nature that one cannot measure or determine. God can inspire into our minds things that we had no previous knowledge of, if He desires to do so.

*(Shoghi Effendi; from a letter written on his behalf, 25 January 1943)*